> Dost Mohammad's comprehension is very quick; his knowledge of character very great; and he cannot be long deceived. He listens to every individual who complains, and with a forbearance and temper which are more highly praised than his equity and justice . . . Whether his religious wars and government have resulted from a strong spirit of orthodoxy or from ambition is a question yet to be solved . . . The republican genius [of the Afghans] is unchanged; and whatever power a Sadozai or a Barakzai may acquire, its preservation can only be ensured by not infringing the rights of the tribes, and the laws by which they are allowed to govern themselves.[53]

Dost Mohammad may have been impressed by Burnes and vice versa, but there is evidence from a variety of Afghan sources even at this early stage that not all of his courtiers, nobles and chiefs were pleased by the growing friendship of their Amir with the Firangi [foreign] infidel. The more orthodox were especially anxious about such an alliance, and wondered how it sat with the Amir's stated intention of declaring war on the enemies of Islam.

In the Afghan sources, Burnes is always depicted as a devilishly charming but cunning deceiver, a master of *zarang*, of flattery and treachery – an interesting inversion of British stereotypes of the devious Oriental. Mirza 'Ata in the *Naway Ma'arek* talks of Burnes's progress up the Indus:

> to spy out conditions in Sindh and Khurasan, which he succeeded in doing thanks to his Plato-like intelligence. Burnes realised that the states of the region were built on very insecure foundations and would need only a gust of wind to blow them down. When the people crowded to stare at the foreigners, Burnes emerged from his tent and jokingly remarked to the crowd 'Come and see my tail and horns!' Everyone laughed, and someone called out: 'Your tail stretches all the way back to England, and your horns will soon be appearing in Khurasan!'[54]

This image is developed by Maulana Kashmiri in his 1844 *Akbarnama*. In this poem, Burnes, the arch-enemy of Akbar Khan, is the demonically charismatic incarnation of all the two-faced treachery and deceit of Crusading Christendom:

> One of the Firangi lords of high stature
> By name Burnes, and called Sikandar
>
> Gathered all the necessaries for commerce
> And set out with every appearance of a trader
>
> When he arrived, with all haste, in the city of Kabul
> He sought intimacy with its illustrious men